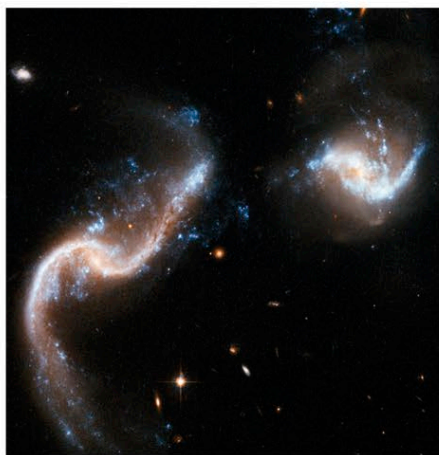




△ Arp 256

Lying about 350 million light-years away, these two galaxies, collectively known as ARP 256, are at an early stage of merging. Their interaction has disrupted their shapes and triggered star formation.

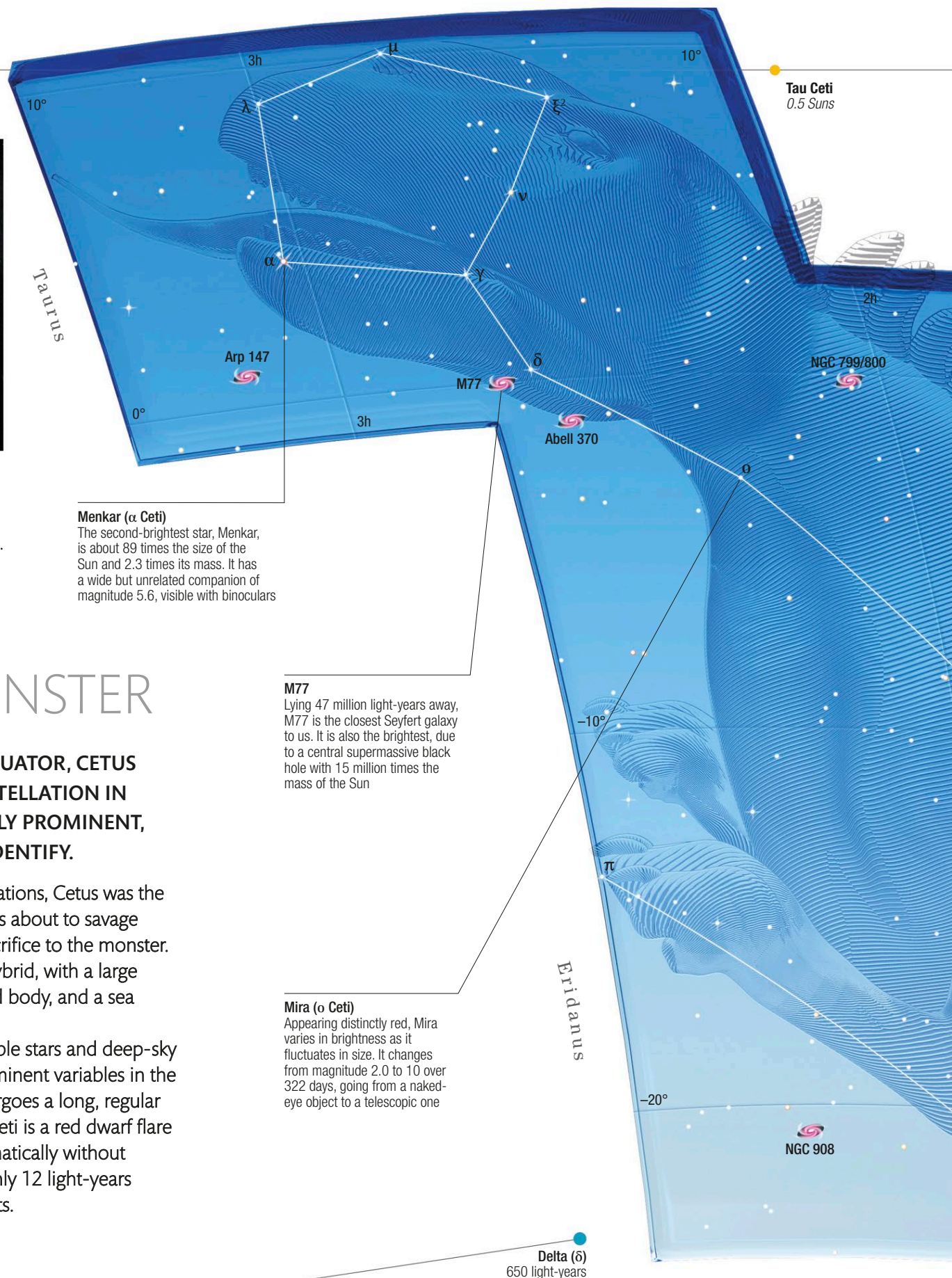
CETUS

THE SEA MONSTER

STRADDLING THE CELESTIAL EQUATOR, CETUS IS THE FOURTH-LARGEST CONSTELLATION IN THE SKY. IT IS NOT PARTICULARLY PROMINENT, SO CAN BE CHALLENGING TO IDENTIFY.

One of the original 48 Greek constellations, Cetus was the sea monster killed by Perseus as it was about to savage Andromeda, chained to cliffs as a sacrifice to the monster. It is often represented as a strange hybrid, with a large head, a land mammal's front legs and body, and a sea serpent's tail.

The constellation has several notable stars and deep-sky objects. Mira is one of the most prominent variables in the sky. Its brightness changes as it undergoes a long, regular cycle of pulsations. In contrast, UV Ceti is a red dwarf flare star whose brightness increases dramatically without warning. Tau Ceti is a Sun-like star only 12 light-years away and is orbited by five exoplanets.



Menkar (α Ceti)

The second-brightest star, Menkar, is about 89 times the size of the Sun and 2.3 times its mass. It has a wide but unrelated companion of magnitude 5.6, visible with binoculars.

M77

Lying 47 million light-years away, M77 is the closest Seyfert galaxy to us. It is also the brightest, due to a central supermassive black hole with 15 million times the mass of the Sun.

Mira (ο Ceti)

Appearing distinctly red, Mira varies in brightness as it fluctuates in size. It changes from magnitude 2.0 to 10 over 322 days, going from a naked-eye object to a telescopic one.

Delta (δ)
650 light-years

Mira (ο) 299 light-years

Theta (θ) 115 light-years

Tau (τ) 12 light-years

Iota (ι) 275 light-years

Earth

Distance

◁ Star distances

Cetus's main pattern stars are situated between 12 and about 650 light-years away. The nearest, Tau (τ) Ceti, is one of the closest yellow main-sequence, Sun-like stars to us. Delta (δ) Ceti, is a blue giant that, as well as being the most distant of Cetus's pattern stars, is also the most luminous, with a luminosity of more than 800 Suns.